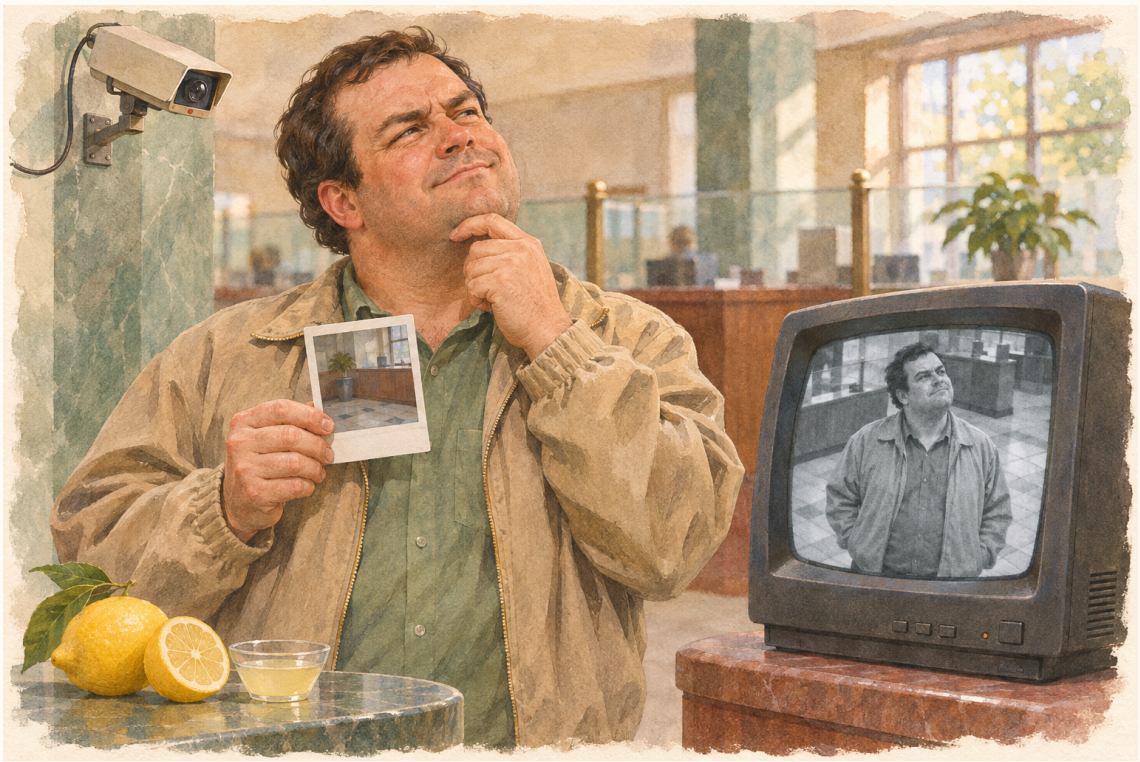
以为柠檬汁能隐身的劫匪

The Robber Who Thought Lemon Juice Made Him Invisible



我们为什么有时看不见自己的判断失误?

READ 纯净阅读

CHECK 中文核对

LEARN 词汇记忆

RECALL 回想巩固

英文原文

On 6 January 1995, McArthur Wheeler and an accomplice raided two Pittsburgh-area banks at gunpoint in broad daylight, without disguise. Their only camouflage was lemon juice, rubbed on in the earnest conviction that it would render them invisible to cameras.

The rationale had a kernel of truth. Lemon juice is a time-honoured invisible ink, and Wheeler made an inventive leap from paper to skin. His Polaroid self-portrait came out devoid of its subject, a result he took as conclusive.

The security cameras begged to differ. On 19 April the eleven o'clock news showed viewers the damning images, and Wheeler was arrested shortly after midnight. Confronted with the tapes, he protested in sheer disbelief that he had worn the juice.

Reading about the case, the Cornell psychologist David Dunning pondered a disquieting proposition. Perhaps incompetence can cloak itself, robbing people of the discernment to notice their deficiencies.

For a 1999 paper, Dunning and his student Justin Kruger quizzed Cornell undergraduates on humour, grammar, and logical reasoning. The bottom quarter of scorers averaged the 12th percentile but generously placed themselves near the 62nd, whereas high achievers showed undue modesty. The unskilled, the authors argued, bear a dual burden, since appraisal calls for the same skills as execution.

Detractors traced part of the Dunning-Kruger disparity to regression to the mean, a statistical mirage the paper partially acknowledged. Studies designed to avoid it still find a smaller but tangible effect. In 2023 the pair garnered the Grawemeyer psychology award.

In fairness, Wheeler had tested his method empirically before staking his liberty on it. The camera that missed him was the one he turned on himself.

中文译文

1995年1月6日，麦克阿瑟·惠勒和一名同伙在大白天持枪抢劫了匹兹堡地区的两家银行，连乔装都没有。他们唯一的伪装是抹在身上的柠檬汁：两人真心相信，这能让自己在摄像头前隐形。

这套想法多少有些事实依据。柠檬汁用作隐形墨水由来已久，惠勒别出心裁，把纸上的道理套到了皮肤上。他用宝丽来相机自拍，照片里却没有自己的身影，他便把这当成了确凿证据。

监控摄像头可不认同这套说法。4月19日晚11点的新闻向观众播出了那些铁证般的画面；午夜刚过不久，惠勒就被捕了。面对录像，他仍难以置信，辩解说自己明明抹了柠檬汁。

读到这个案子后，康奈尔大学心理学家戴维·邓宁思考起一种令人不安的可能：一个人能力不足，也许还会因此缺少判断力，察觉不到自己有哪些不足。

为撰写1999年的一篇论文，邓宁和他的学生贾斯汀·克鲁格测试了康奈尔大学本科生在幽默判断、语法和逻辑推理方面的能力。成绩排在末尾四分之一的学生，平均实际排名只超过约12%的参试者，却以为自己排在约62%的人前面；成绩优异者反而低估了自己的表现。两位作者认为，缺乏相应技能的人面临双重困难，因为评价表现与实际做事，需要的是同样的技能。

批评者认为，邓宁—克鲁格研究中的部分差距来自均值回归，是一种统计假象，原论文也在一定程度上承认了这一点。不过，为规避这个问题而设计的研究，仍发现了较小但确实存在的效应。2023年，两人获得了格文美尔心理学奖。

平心而论，在拿自己的自由做赌注之前，惠勒还真做过实际测试。那台没拍到他的相机，偏偏就是他对准自己的那一台。

读懂 percentile
百分位表示一个人在群体中的相对位置。第12百分位不等于答对了12%的题。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

accomplice n.
同伙；共犯
and an accomplice

raid v.
突袭；文中指持枪抢劫
raided two Pittsburgh-area banks

disguise n.
乔装；伪装
without disguise

conviction n.
坚定的信念
in the earnest conviction

render v.
使……处于某种状态
render them invisible to cameras

rationale n.
推理依据；理由
The rationale had a kernel of truth.

conclusive adj.
确凿的；足以定论的
a result he took as conclusive.

be confronted with 动词短语
面对（被出示的证据）
Confronted with the tapes

ponder v.
仔细思考
pondered a disquieting proposition

proposition n.
观点；待论证的命题
a disquieting proposition

incompetence n.
能力不足
incompetence can cloak itself

discernment n.
辨识力；判断力
the discernment to notice

deficiency n.
不足；能力缺陷
notice their deficiencies

paper n.
论文
For a 1999 paper

logical adj.
逻辑的；合乎逻辑的
logical reasoning

appraisal n.
评估（自身表现）
appraisal calls for the same skills

call for 动词短语
需要；要求
calls for the same skills

execution n.
执行；实际完成任务
the same skills as execution

disparity n.
差异；差距
the Dunning-Kruger disparity

tangible adj.
切实存在的
a smaller but tangible effect

empirically adv.
以观察或实验为依据
tested his method empirically

stake v.
拿……作赌注
staking his liberty on it

文中词汇与搭配

补齐另外34项。这里保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

in broad daylight 介词短语
光天化日之下

camouflage n.
伪装；掩饰手段

rub … on … 动词短语
涂抹在……上

earnest adj.
真诚认真的

kernel n.
一点真实成分

time-honoured adj.
沿用已久的

ink n.
墨水

inventive adj.
富有创意的（此处含调侃）

leap n.
思维上的跳跃

self-portrait n.
自拍照

devoid of 形容词短语
完全没有

beg to differ 动词短语
表示不赞同（拟人反讽）

viewer n.
电视观众

damning adj.
有力证明罪行的

sheer adj.
十足的；完全的

disbelief n.
不相信；难以置信

disquieting adj.
令人不安的

cloak v.
掩盖；遮蔽

rob v.
剥夺（某人拥有的东西）

quiz v.
测试；测验

undergraduate n.
本科生

scorer n.
测验中的答题者

generously adv.
“大方地”高估自己（反讽）

achiever n.
此处指高分者

undue adj.
过分的；不应有的

modesty n.
谦虚；自谦

unskilled adj.
缺乏技能的；文中指能力不足者

dual adj.
双重的

detractor n.
批评者

mirage n.
假象

partially adv.
部分地

garner v.
赢得（奖项）

in fairness 介词短语
平心而论

liberty n.
人身自由

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 The _____ had a kernel of truth.

02 His Polaroid self-portrait came out devoid of its subject, a result he took as _____.

03 The unskilled, the authors argued, bear a dual burden, since _____ calls for the same skills as execution.

04 Studies designed to avoid it still find a smaller but _____ effect.

文章主线

- 误信 劫匪惠勒把柠檬汁的隐形墨水原理误套到皮肤上；自拍没拍到自己，他便当作躲过镜头的验证。
- 落网 他涂着柠檬汁抢银行，仍被监控拍下；新闻播出后被捕，面对录像也不信办法失效。
- 研究 案件启发邓宁与克鲁格研究自评；幽默、语法和逻辑测试中，低分者常高估自己，高分者反而低估。
- 解释 两人认为，完成任务与判断水平需要相同技能，能力不足者可能也难察觉自己的不足。
- 限度 统计因素能解释部分差异；避开这些因素后仍有较小效应，原结论须谨慎看待。

参考答案　1 rationale 2 conclusive 3 appraisal 4 tangible